

More than the camera, it's adoption of the concept we're targeting. Consumers are beginning to realise the ease with which pictures can be captured and printed out. Thanks to digicams, passport-size snaps are available on the spot. We also bundle digicams with photo printers."

HP digicams are available at a price range of Rs 8,500 to Rs 40,000.

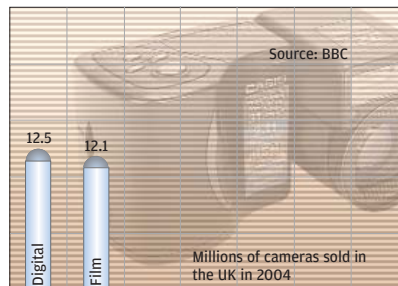
Digit asked Kodak what the major trends in digital photography would be in 2005. According to Richard Fleming, business manager, south Asia, consumer and professional imaging group, Kodak, 2004 was a very important year for the industry as a whole:

"In retrospect, the year saw the myths around using a digital camera diminishing to a large extent. Also, digital cameras are looked at not only as an attractive gift option, but also for personal use—as very good quality entry-level cameras are now available for as low as Rs 6,000 to Rs 7,000."

The major trends in the coming year driving the industry will be as follows, as also indicated by IDC in its half-yearly report:

- ☑ Better pricing across the category
- ☑ Enhancement of features with entry-level moving to higher mega pixels
- ☑ Digital camera becoming a common lifestyle accessory in larger cities
- ☑ Digital cameras and home printers offering a new experience and option to customers

About the evolution of the digital photography market, we were told that IDC had estimated a market size growth of around 68 per cent for 2004. This category has been one of the largest growing one in the digital products segment. With prices of digital cameras coming down year after year, and with possible reduction in import duties, digital cameras are becoming very accessible as



"objects of desire." Both digital capture and output is expected to see a good market from the consumer and business segments who are looking for seamless imaging solutions.

"The introduction of a bundled digital camera, Kodak EasyShare CX 7330 with the Kodak EasyShare Printer Dock—has received good response. Basically, the market is driven by affordability and ease of use. Kodak digicams offer both these in addition to unsurpassed picture quality, incorporating the exclusive Kodak Colour Science image processing chip.

"The Kodak EasyShare system, with its one touch simplicity and ability to deliver quality prints, is driving digital camera household penetration.

"Kodak has always believed in the philosophy of ease of use and simplicity, as conveyed by its founder in the popular slogan, 'You press the button, we do the rest.'

"We will continue to bring in newer cameras in all the categories. We have already launched a five-megapixel camera with a 10X optical zoom with SLR camera-like features—DX 7590. We are also in the process of marketing a new lifestyle camera—LS 755—also a five-megapixel camera with a 3X optical zoom which is not only sleek and stylish but also has a very large 2.5-inch high resolution display for accurate previewing and reviewing of pictures."

We asked Lawrence Gibson, an Indian photography enthusiast based in Saudi Arabia, about what he'd like to see for digicams in 2005. Gibson has owned a Canon Powershot A80 for two years now. He opines that film still has its appeal, and that film cameras produce sharper results. As for digicam pricing, he says that prices are very low as they are—and that they probably won't fall too much now.

However, he still would like to see more features at lower prices in 2005, if that is possible. When we asked Gibson what features he would like to see in digital cameras, he says, "There needs to be more bundled software - for example, software to work with red-eye correction and such. Also, digicams need to get easier to use."

Yes, apart from price, it's all about ease of use. ■

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